
TRAUMA INFORMED CARE AND CHILD-LED SESSIONS

Taysia Vick, BCBA

AGENDA:

- **Trauma informed ABA is good ABA**
- **Assumptions**
- **Bodily Autonomy and Self-Advocacy**
- **Avoiding Power Struggles**
- **Breaking Down Behavior**



TASK LIST RELATIONS

- **E: Responsibility in Practice**
 - **F4: Conduct assessments of relevant skills strengths and deficits**
 - **G4: Use stimulus response prompts and fading**
 - **G20: Use self management strategies**
 - **H5: Unwanted effects of punishment/extinction behaviors**
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WHAT IS COMPASSIONATE AND TRAUMA –INFORMED ABA?

- *What does it mean to you? *Audience participation**

WHAT ARE CHILD-LED SESSIONS? ARE THEY IMPORTANT?

- *What does it mean to you? *Audience participation**

THE SHIFT TO TODAY'S COMPASSIONATE ABA

- Why this topic?
 - Hallmarks of Today's ABA
 - Asking Questions
 - Creating a context in which the probability for problem behavior is zero
 - TEACHING THROUGH JOY
 - Empowering the learner
 - Shaping Skills
 - THEN, teaching everything else...
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THE SHIFT TO TODAY'S COMPASSIONATE ABA

- *The main drivers of behavior change should be properly motivating operations, prompting, and differential reinforcement*
 - *not extinction or punishment*

MAKING PEACEFUL PROGRESS

INTRODUCING OUR PRESENTER:

- Taysia Vick, Lead BCBA, NE

WHAT IS TRAUMA INFORMED CARE?

- Trauma informed care is....
 - Safety
 - Choice
 - Collaboration
 - Trustworthiness
 - Empowerment
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Safety



Ensuring physical and emotional safety

Common areas are welcoming and privacy is respected

Choice



Individual has choice and control

Individuals are provided a clear and appropriate message about their rights and responsibilities

Collaboration



Making decisions with the individual and sharing power

Principles in Practice

Individuals are provided a significant role in planning and evaluating services

Trustworthiness



Task clarity, consistency, and Interpersonal Boundaries

Respectful and professional boundaries are maintained

Empowerment



Prioritizing empowerment and skill building

Providing an atmosphere that allows individuals to feel validated and affirmed with each and every contact at the agency

WHY SHOULD WE ASSUME TRAUMA?

- **Autism and Trauma**
 - People with disabilities and higher risk for abuse/neglect/trauma.
 - Dignity and Respect
 - Adjust our actions to assume
 - Non-vocal, high social emotional needs



BODILY AUTONOMY AND SELF-ADVOCACY

- Autism and self-advocacy
 - DSM-5 Criteria: deficits in social emotional reciprocity, deficits in nonverbal behaviors, deficits in verbal behavior, deficits in developing and maintaining relationships.
- Bodily Autonomy
 - Liberty to do what they want!

“Balancing the right to habilitation with the right to personal liberties: the rights of people with developmental disabilities to eat too many doughnuts and take a nap.”

<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC1286212/x>



HOW TO RESPECT BODILY AUTONOMY

- **Respect bodily autonomy by...**
 - **Addressing need for full physical prompting (also part of trauma informed care)**
 - **Assess body language or ask before touching or placing hands on**
 - **Give warnings before placing hands on during problem behavior**
 - **Too much prompting of any kind can cause reliance and learned helplessness.**
 - **Can make the child more susceptible to abuse in the future**
 - **Ask permission when you can**
 - **Fade prompts as soon as possible**
 - **Most common instances of skill building that might require hands on or could be helpful: handwriting, hand washing**
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AVOIDING POWER STRUGGLES

- What is a power struggle?
 - Can be physically removing an item/pulling an item or can be verbal through arguments/continuous prompting
 - An attempt to use threats or force in response to challenging behavior. Can happen when you are beginning to place a demand or when they are starting to escalate.
 - 4 main types of power struggles: Defending one's authority, personal button pushing, bringing up history/irrelevant issues, and making empty threats or issuing ultimatums.
 - Why to avoid?
 - Safety Care Training: engaging in a power struggle is not respecting client dignity
 - Q-TIP: Quit Taking It Personal
 - Pick your battles
 - Give the person time!
 - Connect with them!
 - Can cause unwanted new problem behaviors or exacerbation of current problem behaviors.
 - Breaks trust and the pairing relationship. Creates space between the people, and focuses on compliance rather than working together.
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POWER STRUGGLES CONT.

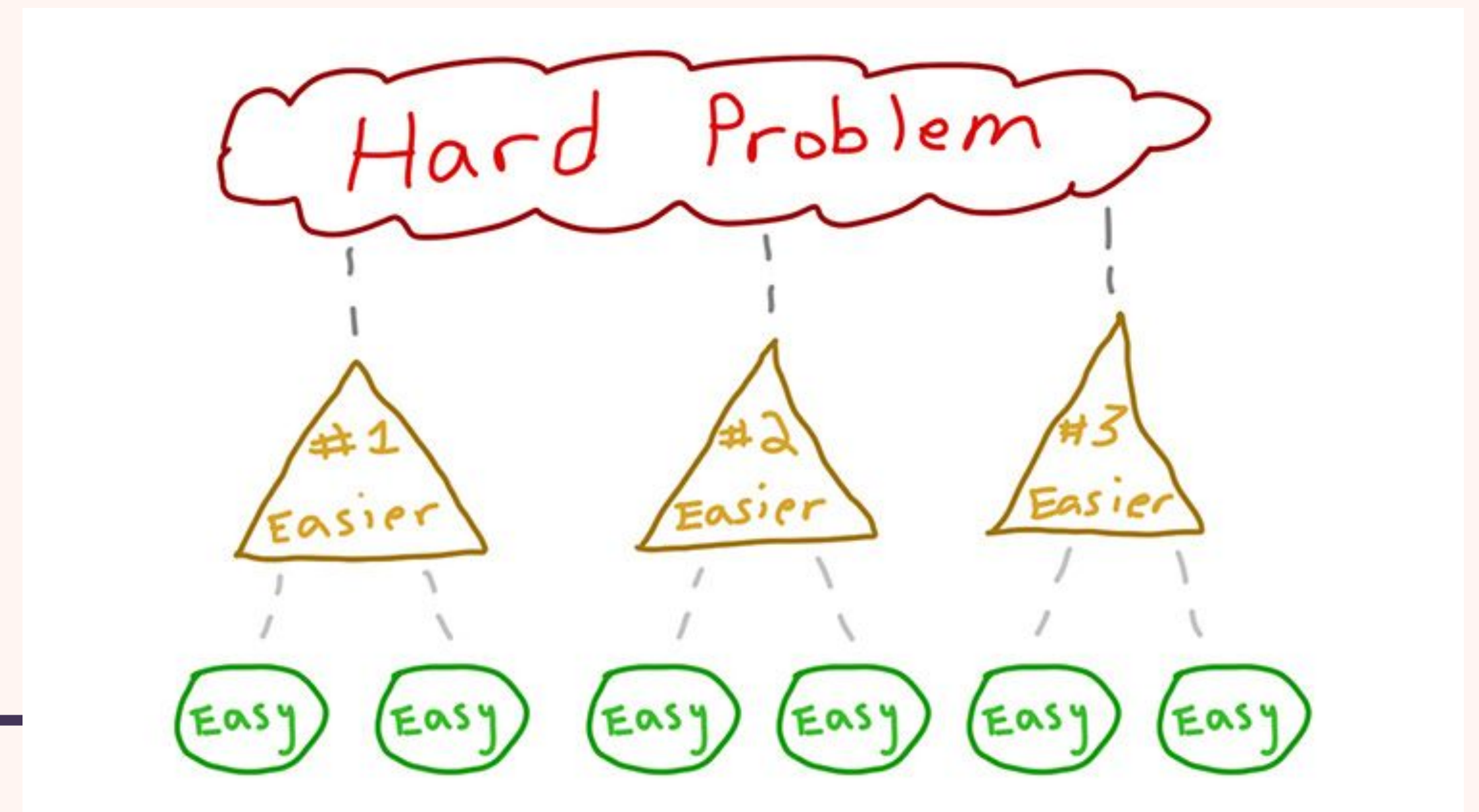
- **Solutions to power struggles:**
 - **Child-led sessions - creates a child-focused and truly individualized session.**
 - **Children are in charge of the pace**
 - **Less about compliance, and more about meeting them where they are at.**
 - **You can do this while maintaining boundaries and a safe environment**
 - **Talk to them about the boundaries**
 - **Hold your boundaries, but be willing to negotiate when appropriate**
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NATURAL ENVIRONMENT TEACHING

- Child-led sessions are more natural and play based.
 - They integrate PRT - pivotal response training and Play Therapy.
 - Imitation training
 - Creates natural generalization
- Longer breaks and focus on the client being content!
 - “Breaks” should be used as time to implement natural programs with them.
 - <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=V-c50HNnPg0>
 - Get creative with your DTT programs. Many can be implemented in play.

BREAKING DOWN SKILLS

- Practicing Component-Composite Skills
 - Identification of all precursor skills required for completion of a behavior
 - For example: a pre-requisite to handwriting could be ability to grip the pencil correctly
 - Analysis of strength or weaknesses of each of these
 - If a skill is not making progress, assume it is due to lack of pre-requisite skills or reinforcer efficacy.
- Practice:
 - Hand Washing
 - What pre-requisite skills would be needed here?
- Great assessment for pre-requisite skills:
 - ABLLS-R



COMPONENT/COMPOSITE SKILL ANALYSIS

- **Component:** A piece or skill that is a part of a composite
 - **Composite:** A skill that is made up of many smaller skills
 - **Let's practice breaking down a skill together:**
 - **Receptive Identification of Numbers in a messy array of 6**
 - **Practice in small groups:**
 - **Writing name on the top of their paper independently when they receive a worksheet for class.**
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PRE-REQUISITE SKILLS: ABLLS-R ASSESSMENT

- **Let's find some great pre-requisite skills in the ABLLS-R Assessment (Assessment of Basic Language and Learning Skills)**
 - **Sections that I find most useful:**
 - **Very beginner and basic attending to people, building joint attention and general engagement: A: Cooperation and Reinforcer Effectiveness, D: Motor imitation, E: Vocal Imitation**
 - **Beginner Language (vocal or non-vocal): C: Receptive Language, F: Requests,**
 - **Beginner Social Behavior (with peers or others): K Play and leisure skills, L: Social interactions**
 - **Writing and Fine Motor: S: Writing Skills, Z: Fine Motor Skills**
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ABLLS-R EXAMPLE

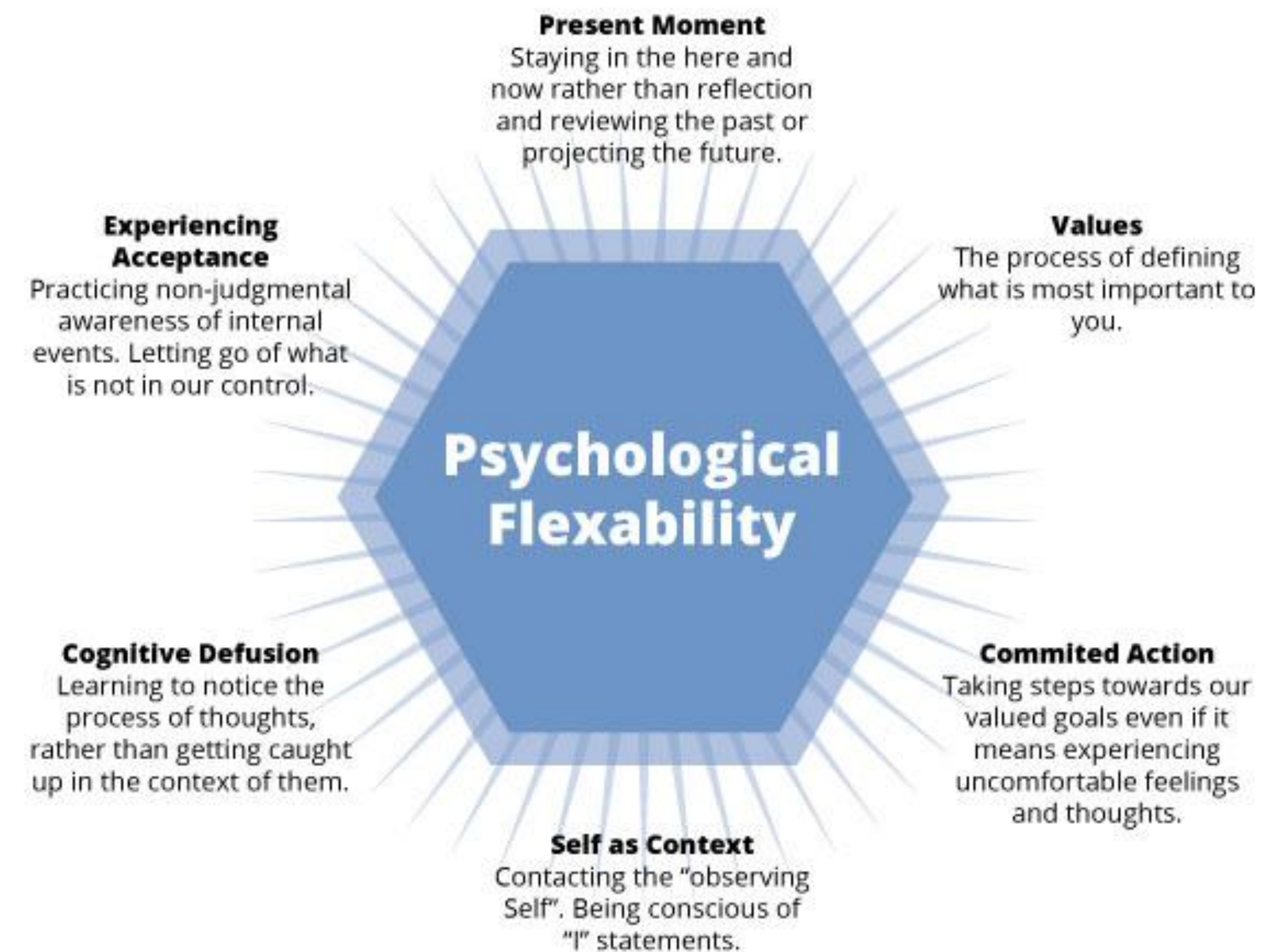
COOPERATION AND REINFORCER EFFECTIVENESS

TASK	SCORE	TASK NAME	TASK OBJECTIVE	QUESTION	EXAMPLES	CRITERIA
A 1	0 1 2 0 1 2 0 1 2 0 1 2	Take reinforcer when offered	When offered a known reinforcing item or activity, the student will take/ use the item or activity.	When you hold out and offer a known reinforcer, will the student take the reinforcer?	M & M taken and eaten	2= takes within 3 seconds all the time, 1= either not all the time or takes more than 3 seconds to respond
A 2	0 1 2 0 1 2 0 1 2 0 1 2	Take a reinforcer from two choices of items	When offered one reinforcing item or activity and another non-reinforcing item or activity, the student will select the reinforcing item or activity.	When you hold out and offer a reinforcer and a non-reinforcing item, will the student take the reinforcer?	M & M vs. shoe, will take M & M	2= takes within 3 seconds all the time, 1= either not all the time or takes more than 3 seconds to respond
A 3	0 1 2 3 4 0 1 2 3 4 0 1 2 3 4 0 1 2 3 4	Look at a non-reinforcing item	Student will look at and track changes in location of a non-reinforcing item presented by an instructor.	If you hold up a non-reinforcing item, will the student look at it and watch it as you move it to different locations in front of the student?	When you hold up a shoe and ask the student to look at the shoe, student will look at it and watch it as you move it to a variety of positions in front of him (e.g., up/ down/left/right)	4= will track the movement of the item to 6 different positions in a 10 second period, 3= will track the movement of the item to 4 positions in 10 seconds, 2= finds it in any position (up/down/left/ right) within 3 seconds, 1= will look at item but requires an additional prompt to look or takes more than 3 seconds to respond

USING ACT AND VALUES-BASED LIVING APPROACHES

- What is ACT? How does it relate to trauma informed care
 - The Hexaflex
 - Values-Based Approach
 - AIM
- Considerations
- Resources in the ShareDrive
- Example: Let's do a daily activity together.
- Scoring

The Hexaflex



ADVOCACY

- **An important part of being a good behavior analyst is ensuring our clients receive the services they need as well as ethical service delivery.**
- **Advocating with schools**
 - **Be willing to compromise**
 - **Get a second opinion from a lead or director**

MAIN POINTS

- **Assume trauma and act as such**
 - **Behavior occurs for a reason**
 - **Validate feelings**
 - **Break down skills when needed**
 - **Focus on child-led sessions and play**
 - **Always place a focus on prompt fading**
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RESOURCES

“Balancing the right to habilitation with the right to personal liberties: the rights of people with developmental disabilities to eat too many doughnuts and take a nap.”

<https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC1286212/>

ABLLS-R Assessment - Available in Central Reach

“Toward trauma-informed applications of behavior analysis”

<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/34525220/>

https://collective.dobettermovement.us/training/?yith_wcan=1&filter_ceu-type=ethics&query_type_ceu-type=or

<https://www.emergentlearningacademy.com/training-1-1>
